

BEST Management Advice

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"TOMORROW'S BEST MIDDLE MANAGERS ARE REINVENTING THEMSELVES TODAY"

Q Middle managers are increasingly expected to manage people, technology, and business transformation at the same time. What are the most critical skills they need to develop?

The expectations from middle managers have not changed, but the ambiguity and complexity have grown. As a result, they must lead differently.

To cut through complexity and inspire their teams to focus on what matters most, middle managers will need to exercise thoughtful decision-making, strategic communication, and genuine empathy. Equally important is their ability to lead through change while helping their teams build new skills and confidence in working with AI.

Q Many middle managers are promoted because they are



strong individual contributors but may not have been trained to manage people. What capabilities should organisations prioritise?

The transition from individual contributor to manager is a pivotal shift.

Organisations should equip managers to balance three priorities: business needs, individual aspirations, and long-term capability building. When managers do this well, they become talent builders and force multipliers for the organisation.

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Q With AI changing how work gets done, what new skills should middle managers be building today?

As AI becomes embedded in everyday work, managers need AI fluency themselves. Even more critical is the ability to lead people supported by AI agents, enabling effective human-agent collaboration while keeping human judgment at the center. The best way to build these skills is in the flow of work.

Q If you could give middle managers one advice on investing in their own learning and staying relevant what would it be?

Stay curious enough to unlearn. The skills that made you successful may not be the ones that matter most tomorrow. That's why your biggest competitive advantage will be how quickly you can unlearn, learn, and help others do the same. Make learning part of how you work every day. Experiment with AI, take on unfamiliar assignments, and learn from people across functions and generations. Deepen your expertise but also broaden your outlook by understanding how the business creates value and what matters most to your clients. **BT**